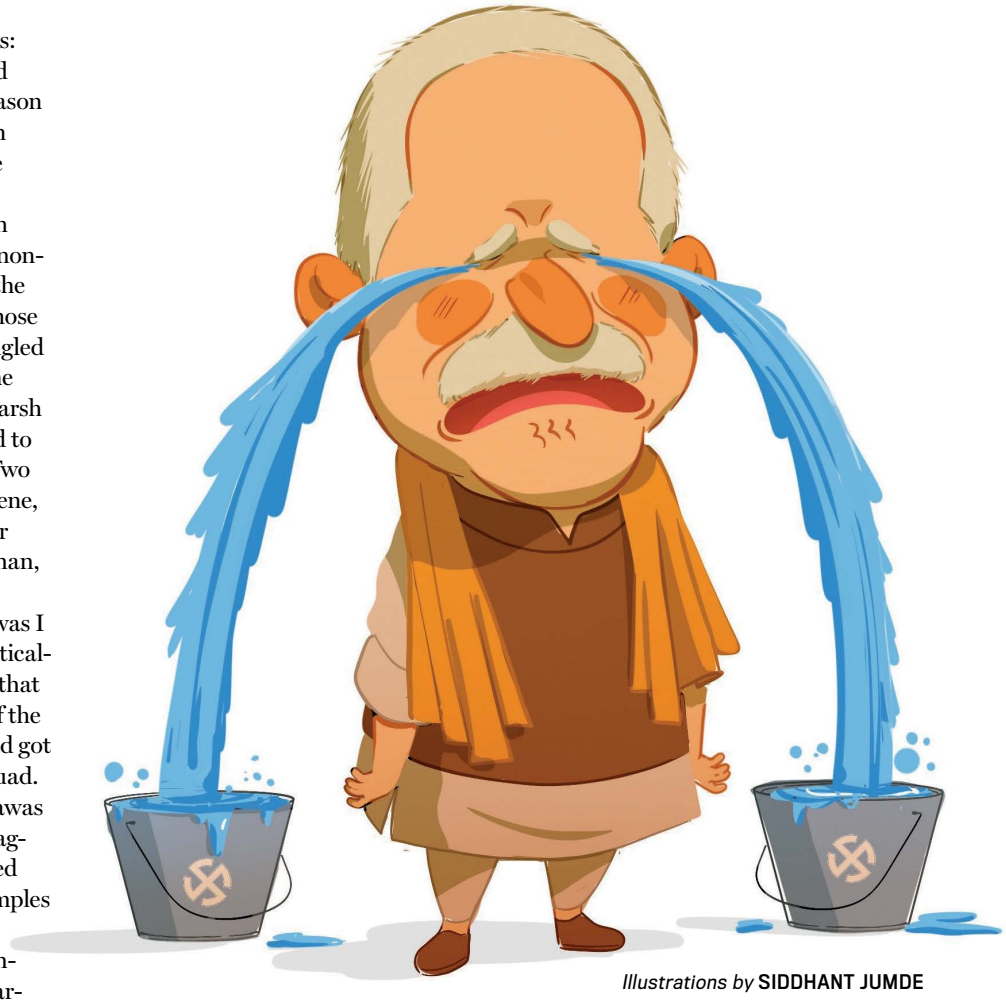
A DELUGE OF POLITICAL TEARS

Politics can be like onions: layers within layers, and plenty tears. For one reason or the other, everyone in Rajasthan is sobbing on stage. The latest to wax lachrymose is Ravi Nayyar, owner of Roshan Dhaba in Jaipur's Raja Park. Famous for its non-vegetarian delicacies for decades, the dhaba suddenly stopped serving those and turned all *satvik* as Nayyar angled for a BJP ticket. For his penance, he was rewarded with a boon: the Adarsh Nagar seat. That's when he decided to really sink his teeth into the role. Two cows and a calf appeared on the scene, posthumously. At a presser, Nayyar boohooed as he accused Rafeek Khan, his opponent and sitting Congress MLA, of culpable bovicide. "Why was I not shot instead?" he asked dramatically, through tears. Khan dismissed that as a cheap stunt and called himself the real *gau rakshak*, citing how he had got cows freed from a municipality squad. Minister Pratap Singh Khachariyawas weighed in, accusing the BJP of staging its old street theatre and advised Hindus to keep their cattle and temples locked at night till voting day.

It's Archana Sharma of the Congress who launched a thousand teardrops when she reminded her Malviya Nagar electorate how she has lost twice, the last time by a mere 2,000 votes, and this one could be her life's.... (lost in tears). Her party mate Pushpendra Bhardwaj from Sanganer sobbed about how politics keeps him away from his seven-year-old daughter for days. The BJP's Priyanka Chaudhary (Barmer) and Congressmen Bharosi Lal Jatav (Hindon) and Khiradi Lal Bairwa (Baseri) cried publicly for being denied tickets. In a different class is Om Prakash Hudla, sitting independent MLA who has got a Congress ticket from Mahuwa. His grief: an ED raid. ■



Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

GET TICKLED PINK

Most people with drive, who look at cars as a means of transport from a lesser station in life to a greater one, go after muscular off-roaders with big fat wheels or sleek sedans. But in Telangana, the quest for upwardly mobility forces BRS candidates to go for retro chic—in the familiar, bulbous shape of an Ambassador car. Can't be helped. It's a lookalike of the party poll symbol. But where to get your hands on this once-